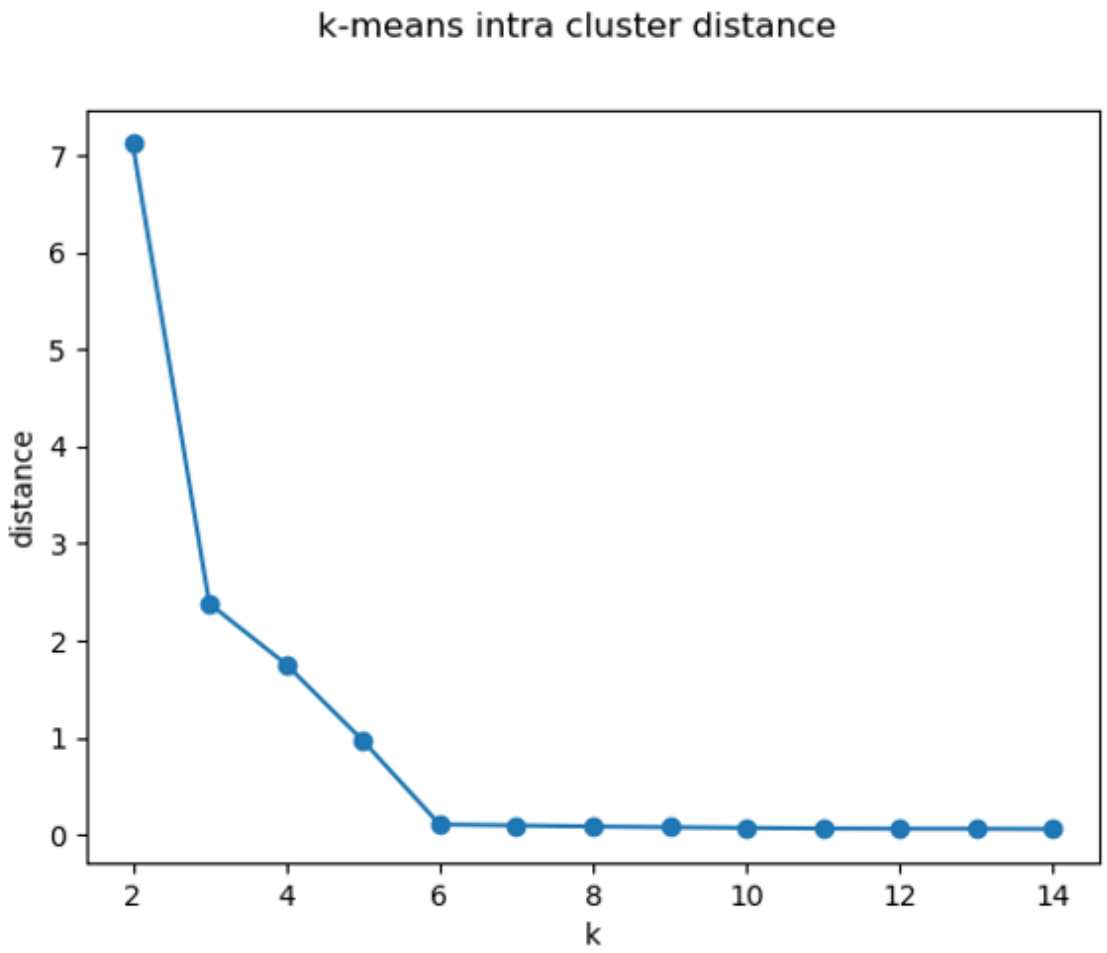


Figure 12.25 The “elbow method” used to decide what’s the best value for the number of clusters into which the dataset in figure 12.24 should be split. You can guess where the name comes from...

From figure 12.25 you can guess where the name of this method comes from: the plot looks like a bent arm, and we want to choose the value corresponding to the elbow, the point where the growth of the function changes drastically.

For our example, that value is k=6: after that, the metric value improves very little. For real datasets, the transition can be less neat (in this case, clusters are very compact and